
Gallarus Oratory

A companion for the threshold

Before you step inside, pause at the door. It is small enough that you have to lower your head to enter. Notice that.

When you are inside, let yourself be still. The stone has held this shape for over a thousand years. Other people have stood where you are standing. They came here carrying two things that every human being carries: the knowledge that they exist, and the knowledge that someday they will not. You carry the same two things. You do not need to do anything with them yet. Just let them be present with you in this space.

After a few minutes, ask yourself quietly: what brought me to this edge of the world? Not the course, not the itinerary. What in you responded when you said yes to this journey?

Sit with whatever comes. If nothing comes, sit with the nothing. That is not failure. The monks who built this place knew that silence is not empty.

When you are ready to leave, step back out and write one sentence in your field journal. Not a description of the oratory. Not an analysis. One sentence that begins:

“What I am carrying out of that place that I did not carry in is...”

If nothing changed, write that. That is also true, and truth is where the journey starts.

A note for those who felt nothing

If you stepped inside and felt nothing in particular, write that. Honestly. It is a legitimate response and the journey does not require you to perform an experience you did not have. Sometimes a place does not speak to us on first encounter. Sometimes it speaks later, when we are somewhere else entirely and least expecting it. Write what was actually true for you, and trust that.

Field journal — write here or in your journal
